

Xenophanes – evidence and true belief



Like Pythagoras, Xenophanes of Colophon was an Ionian-born philosopher who travelled widely, spending most of a reputedly long life moving from one Greek colony to another. His theory of cosmic composition involved two alternating extremes of wet and dry – neatly combining the Milesian ideas of pure elements of air and water (see [Thales of Miletus](#) and [Anaximander and Anaximenes](#)) with Heraclitus's theory of opposites (see [Xenophanes – evidence and true belief](#)). What was more significant, however, was the fact that he used fossils to back up his idea that the world

was once covered by water – one of the first examples of evidence-based argument.

Xenophanes is also credited with being the first philosopher to deal with questions of epistemology, suggesting that when we say we ‘know’ something, that knowledge is actually only a ‘true belief’ – a hypothesis good enough for us to work from. A ‘truth of reality’ does exist, but this will always be beyond our human understanding; the best we can do is refine our hypotheses to continually get nearer to it.